

Five 'New' AA Pilots All Played in League

The American Association will open its 57th campaign with three brand new managers, a fourth on a different job and a fifth starting his first full year as an AA pilot.

Baseball Scrapbook

by BOB
BEEBE

Gene Mauch at Minneapolis, Walker Cooper at Indianapolis and Del Wilber at Louisville are making their debuts as managers in this oldest of the big minors. Andy Cohen has switched from Indianapolis to Denver, and Bill Norman is back at Charleston after taking over from Frank Skaff last July 6 and steering the

Senators through the last 71 games of the 1957 campaign. All five have one thing in common: they all played in the Association. This makes it unanimous for the league's eight managers although Johnny Keane of Omaha made the American Association Alumni club by playing



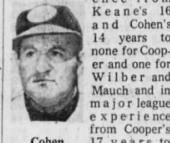
Cooper Mauch

a scant eight games for Columbus back in 1932.

Strangely, none of them will manage the AA team he played for.

The managers' playing time in the loop ranges down from Norman's 10 years with St. Paul, Louisville and Milwaukee. Cohen was Minneapolis' second baseman for seven consecutive years (1932-38); Mauch played four years for St. Paul, Indianapolis and Milwaukee; St. Paul's Max Macon pitched three seasons for Columbus; Cooper (1940) and Wilber (1946) each caught a year for Columbus and Ben Geraghty of Wichita played one season at Indianapolis (1945).

In age they range from Cohen's 53 to Mauch's 32 years; in managerial experi-



Cohen

ence from Keane's 16 and Cohen's 14 years to none for Cooper and one for Wilber and Mauch and in major league experience from Cooper's 17 years to

none for Keane and the couple of "cups of coffee" Norman had with the Chicago Cubs.

Two of the new managers will be on the active list. Cohen plans to be his own regular second baseman; Cooper, despite 25 years of baseball, hopes to play in "about 50 games" for the Indians.

Most famous of the group is Cooper, the big catcher who teamed with Morton Cooper on the St. Louis Cardinals in a great brother battery; hit .333 in five all-star games; 300 in 16 World Series contests and made the major league All-Star team three times . . . Wilber, now 39, like Cooper, a big fellow of 6-3 and 220, played eight major league seasons and was on the Miller roster in the winter of 1955 before getting a coaching job with the Chicago White Sox . . . In his one previous year of managing (1949) he finished seventh in the Texas league at Houston . . .

Cohen broke in with the New York Giants in 1926 as a pinch hitter for the great Frankie Frisch and singled. Played two seasons of second



Norman Wilber

base for John McGraw, then was shipped down . . . Has won three pennants and finished in the first division nine times in 14 years of managing. Wound up sixth at Indianapolis last year . . .

Norman never failed to hit 300 in his AA decade and led the league in homers with 24 in 1942 . . . At 48, he has managed nine years, winning two pennants and winding up seventh at Charleston last year . . . Mauch, despite his comparative youth, has played 15 years and finished third in the Southern Association with Atlanta in 1953, a his one season as a manager . . .

Keane, starting his seventh consecutive year in the AA, is the dean . . . Macon is next with three years behind him at St. Paul, while Geraghty will be aiming to make it two flags in two years at Wichita . . .

THE MINNEAPOLIS STAR

SPORTS

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Lakers Remain But Need a Pro to Run Show

★ THE MINNEAPOLIS LAKERS will be in the National Basketball association for another year because no one wants them.

That may be putting the matter rather bluntly, but it's the only interpretation that can be placed on the league's action in approving continuance of the pro game here for one more year.

There are no buyers for the Lakers as they stand now. The reason is obvious. The league club owners feel that Minneapolis doesn't have the kind of a team that will be any better than last for another year.

The NBA has no city so hungry for a professional cage franchise that it will take anything (in this case the Lakers) in the way of a team to get into the sport.

All restrictions on the Minneapolis operation such as advance sale of tickets, total season sales and others, imposed a year ago, have been lifted.

Could the NBA say in any plainer language that the local situation is hopeless?

This imposes a tremendous task on the public spirited and sports minded local individuals who are willing to risk another bundle of money next season in order to keep the Lakers here.

The so-called New Lakers' management has done nothing but make mistakes since the 117 stockholders took over the franchise more than a year ago.

There is no evidence now that more and costlier mistakes will not be made in the year ahead.

Professional basketball, like all sports, is a peculiar business that only those with years of experience in it can handle satisfactorily.

The Minneapolis Lakers need a PRO to run the entire works or they will continue to butt their heads against a stone wall.

And even an outstanding pro may have difficulty reviving this project.

First he must get the talent that will make the local entry a reasonable contender in the NBA. As has been pointed out so often, that's a man-sized job even for one who knows every angle to this sport.

Cus D'Amato says he'll announce a 1958 match for his heavyweight champion, Floyd Patterson, within the week. Any more delays and he'll be looking for some one to finance his title holder.

Kids Like to Play

★ DICK SIEBERT, University of Minnesota baseball coach, will argue with anyone who says youngsters today don't like to play this game.

"Just come over and watch our Gophers any day if you don't believe me," Dick said rather emphatically to a luncheon group the other day. "It thrills me to note the attitude of these youngsters. They want to play and put as much effort and enthusiasm into it as a coach could demand."

"I recently saw some figures that showed there are 7,200,000 boys playing baseball in one league classification or another in this country. That indicates this sport still is our national pastime,"

the Gophers coach declared.



Siebert



By Charles Johnson

LOWDOWN

ON
SPORTS